international law, Iraq and Israel have been in a state of war from 1948 until today.

The 1958 revolution in Iraq overthrew the monarchy and turned the country into a military dictatorship that relied on the Sunni minority in a country with a predominantly Shiite population. General Abd al-Karim Qasim established the military dictatorship and changed the country's orientation from an Iraq that was pro-Western to an Iraq that tied its fate to the Soviet Union and the Eastern bloc. After five years in power, Qasim was deposed in a coup initiated by his ally-turned-rival, Colonel Abdul Salam Arif. Arif was killed three years later in a helicopter accident and was briefly replaced by his weaker brother. His brother was then replaced by a general named Ahmed Hassan al-Bakr, who had participated in the pro-Nazi revolt in Iraq in 1941. Under al-Bakr's rule, a young citizen named Saddam Hussein quickly rose through the ranks to become appointed deputy chairman of the Revolutionary Command Council, the body that ruled Iraq in practice.

From its establishment as a monarchy in the Sykes-Picot Agreement of 1916, during the First World War, Iraq was a rich and powerful country. It had a large area of about half a million square kilometers, with a relatively small population of about fifteen million (in the 1970s). It had an abundance of water, with the Euphrates and Tigris crossing it from the north, from Syria in the northwest and from Turkey in the north, respectively, to the south and east into the Persian Gulf. Iraq was also rich in the energy resources of oil and gas, as well as in agricultural land, and it had a sea outlet in the Persian Gulf. The military dictatorship that ruled the country beginning in 1958 built up a large military force, with the help of the Soviets, in order to create a deterrent against Iran and Turkey; suppress the Kurds in the mountainous north of the country, who had always aspired toward autonomy and independence; develop a position of strategic superiority within the Arab world; and lead the Arab coalitions on the eastern front against Israel.

Despite being in Israel's "outer circle," with no shared border with it, Iraq was a major threat to Israel and a core element of its security doctrine. From its establishment until the outbreak of the "Arab Spring," Israel treated Iraq as a constant threat that had to be taken into account and regarding which a response had to be prepared in the event of any military flare-up in the Middle East.